



Aligning Agendas in Public-Activity Reports: Provincial Leaders and Central Signals in China, 2016–2022

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Abstract

Official communication conveys regime priorities, but we know less about how elites use routine reporting to signal upward and how this shapes authoritarian issue politics. Using 71,460 official public-activity news releases (2016–2022) for the General Secretary, the Premier, provincial party secretaries, and governors, we build a shared issue agenda with a topic model and estimate distributed-lag panel models of responsiveness. Provincial leaders' issue shares track shifts in the General Secretary's attention far more than the Premier's, even after accounting for baseline differences and common shocks. Alignment is strongest on issues closely associated with the General Secretary. Heterogeneity is mainly institutional: party secretaries respond more than governors. Observable factional proximity is linked to at most small, inconsistent differences within offices. Routine public-activity reporting thus serves as an upward-facing signaling channel and clarifies how agenda control operates in a centralized authoritarian system.

Keywords Authoritarian issue politics · Elite signaling · Propaganda in China · Factionalism in Xi-era China · Provincial agenda alignment

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Introduction

Political elites often build their reputations by aligning with specific policy issues. In electoral democracies, parties forge lasting associations with issues such as welfare, taxation, and law and order. They emphasize these “owned” issues to gain voter support [1–3]. In authoritarian regimes, even without competitive elections, elites seek to build reputations and signal their policy priorities and competencies through public communication. Shih, [4] shows that propaganda can function as a loyalty test, and Huang, [5] highlights how propaganda helps manage relationships among rulers, elites, and citizens. However, the ways in which authoritarian elites organize their issue attention—and the influence of leadership structures and factional dynamics on these patterns—remain underexplored.

This article focuses on Xi Jinping’s China, a personalist one-party regime with a dominant leadership coalition [6, 7]. Provincial officials have strong incentives to respond to signals from the general secretary (GS), and recent studies show that central priorities are transmitted unevenly across local policy arenas through vertical pressure, campaign-style enforcement, and intergovernmental diffusion [8–10]. We use “authoritarian issue politics” to describe patterned issue emphasis in official public-activity reports as a form of upward-facing signaling toward the party center. Rather than generalize to all autocracies, we treat Xi-era China as a focused case of elite signaling under a dominant-faction setting.

Empirically, this study addresses three questions. First, to what extent do provincial leaders align the issue agenda of their public activities with signals from the GS rather than the premier? Second, on which issues are they most responsive to the GS’s signals? Third, how do factional position and institutional role shape the strength of this signaling? Here, issue signaling refers to repeated emphasis on particular policy issues in public-activity reports as a visible indicator of priorities and alignment. We capture signaling intensity by the share of attention devoted to an issue and how that share shifts when central priorities change.

To address these questions, a new dataset is compiled. It includes 71,460 official news releases documenting the daily public activities of the GS, the premier, provincial party secretaries (PPSs), and provincial governors (PGs) from 2016 to 2022. These public-activity reports, produced by the CCP’s propaganda apparatus, record leaders’ travel, meetings, and the issues they are presented as promoting for both domestic and international audiences [11]. A nonnegative matrix factorization (NMF) topic model is applied to Chinese-language reports on the GS and the premier. This results in 34 topics that form a shared issue space for all the actors. For each topic, the most frequent words and representative documents are reviewed, allowing a comparison of the attention the GS and the premier have devoted over time. Topics that consistently receive greater attention from the GS and reflect his signature ideological or policy themes are classified as GS-owned issues, while others are categorized as premier-owned. The GS-owned issues align with key themes identified in previous studies of Xi’s leadership, such as ideological discipline, anticorruption, targeted poverty alleviation, and major national development strategies [12, 13]. Topic-specific keyword sets from the model are used to calculate the share of coverage devoted to each topic by actor and month. This creates a monthly panel of issue-

attention shares for the GS, premier, PPSs, and PGs. Finally, vector autoregression and province–topic distributed lag models with fixed effects and two-way clustered standard errors are estimated to analyze how provincial agendas adjust over time in response to shifts in central leaders’ issue attention.

The analysis produces three principal findings. First, provincial leaders’ agendas closely and consistently align with the GS’s agenda. When the GS focuses more on particular issues, provincial attention to those issues rises, especially among PPSs. This pattern remains even after accounting for earlier agendas and signals from the premier, whose effect is weaker. Second, provincial responsiveness is highly selective. On GS-owned issues, both PPSs and PGs change their agendas more than on routine administrative matters. Third, variation among elites exists but is limited. PPSs react more than PGs do, which is consistent with their closer integration into the party command chain. Within each office, however, we find limited and unsystematic evidence that factional proximity systematically conditions responsiveness to GS signals on GS-owned issues.

These results contribute to existing research in three principal ways. First, the study introduces the logic of issue politics into a highly centralized, nonelectoral context, conceptualizing authoritarian issue politics as upward, issue-specific signaling within a bureaucratic hierarchy rather than as competition for voter support [1–3]. Second, it advances the study of political propaganda in China by analyzing routine public-activity reports—an essential component of the CCP’s propaganda system—not only as tools for shaping public opinion but also as venues where elites manage their reputations and demonstrate loyalty to the party center [60]. [5, 14, 15]. Analysis of a monthly dataset of more than 70,000 such public-activity reports reveals that provincial leaders devote more attention to the core agenda of the GS than to signals from the premier. More broadly, the paper also speaks to the public administration literature, which is increasingly attentive to how AI is reshaping the production and diffusion of knowledge in the field itself [16]. Third, the study introduces a communication-based mechanism to the literature on loyalty and factional politics in China. While prior research has focused primarily on factional ties in appointments and policy implementation [4, 6, 7, 17, 18], other work highlights how core and peripheral elites differ in their use of authoritarian representative institutions and other public-facing venues to pursue influence [19]. Overall, the evidence from routine propaganda suggests that issue-based signaling is more consistently patterned by institutional role than by factional rank in a personalist setting dominated by a single faction.

Propaganda, Issue Politics, and Elite Signaling in Authoritarian Regimes

Research on authoritarian propaganda has moved beyond seeing it as simple top-down indoctrination. Recent work highlights propaganda as a tool for signaling regime strength, managing information, and coordinating elites, not just persuading citizens [5, 20–22]. In China, scholars show that the party-state mixes “hard” propaganda in official media with more engaging “soft” forms in entertainment and digital

platforms. These channels help shape public discourse and project competence and control [14, 23]. This research stresses that propaganda outlets are not neutral information channels. They are political instruments within bureaucratic hierarchies.

Within this broader field, research increasingly highlights the inward-facing role of propaganda aimed at elite audiences. Shih, [4] demonstrates how provincial newspapers were used to stage excessive displays of loyalty during ideological campaigns under Jiang Zemin, allowing top leaders to monitor factional dynamics. Later studies suggest that local officials can use their influence over media outlets to cultivate favor with central authorities and, at times, seek political protection [24]. Extending this perspective, Yan and Yang, [25] find that provincial party secretaries actively shape official reports of their daily activities to craft distinct personal images—focused on competence, benevolence, loyalty, or versatility—using the propaganda system to advance individual career goals while still operating within a standardized propaganda format. Taken together, this research suggests that political propaganda in contemporary autocracies serves dual audiences: it projects regime narratives to the public while enabling subnational elites to signal alignment and initiative to their superiors.

A second line of research examines issue attention and rhetorical strategy in authoritarian politics. Classic theories of issue ownership, developed in democratic contexts, argue that parties build reputations for competence in specific policy areas and strategically emphasize “their” issues to attract voters [2, 3]. In nondemocratic systems, citizens cannot assign issue reputations through elections, but the core idea—that issue emphasis reflects strategic choices shaped by institutional and audience constraints—remains useful. Recent work extends this logic to authoritarian settings, asking how rulers and officials adjust their rhetoric across issues in response to political incentives.

Comparative studies of authoritarian speeches show that leaders adapt their communication strategies—emphasizing performance, nationalism, or coercion—depending on economic conditions, elections, protests, or sanctions [26]. Baturo et al., [27] use Russian gubernatorial speeches to show that regional elites echo the leader more closely when repression intensifies or when the ruler’s popularity increases, a pattern often interpreted as loyalty signaling under personalist rule. Khokhlov and Baturo, [28] further argue that authoritarian speakers adjust the complexity of their language to anticipated audiences, underscoring that official communication is a strategic adaptation rather than routine propaganda. Together, these studies demonstrate that issue emphasis and rhetorical choices in autocracies are shaped by both regime incentives and audience structures.

Research on China’s agenda setting and executive politics complements these comparative insights. Quantitative analyses of central policy documents and media reveal that, compared with the fragmented agenda under Hu Jintao, Xi Jinping has recentralized priorities, shifted key domains from the State Council to party leadership, and expanded the range of “core” ideological and security issues under his direct control [11, 12]. Moreover, studies of state and commercial media show how propaganda content varies across outlets and regions and how local authorities use new digital platforms, including social media, for both public persuasion and self-promotion [14, 23, 29]. Recent work on digital governance further suggests that these

shifting priorities are embedded in concrete policy infrastructures, including surveillance procurement, national government big data platforms, administrative burden reduction, and AI adoption in public administration [30–33]. Taken together, this scholarship demonstrates that central leaders define a moving “core agenda,” while propaganda implementation remains partly decentralized. However, we still know little about how individual provincial leaders align their issue portfolios with the top leader’s shifting priorities in their daily public activities—and how rapidly such alignment occurs.

A third line of research focuses on factional politics and elite diversity in authoritarian regimes. In China, scholarship shows that factional ties and patronage networks shape both resource allocation and the career advancement of officials [18, 34]. Related work treats loyalty signaling as a strategic response to uncertainty about the ruler’s preferences and to the threat of repression, though most studies infer it from appointments, purges, or high-profile campaigns rather than routine behavior [4, 27].

Research on authoritarian legislatures and consultative bodies also underscores the importance of distinguishing between core and peripheral elites. Wiebrecht, [19] finds that in China’s provincial People’s Political Consultative Conferences, powerful “core” elites with direct access to decision-making often remain inactive, whereas peripheral elites without such access rely heavily on these institutions to express demands and secure resources. This work highlights how positional differences within the regime, especially unequal access to decision-makers and the channels available for claim-making, shape how elites use public institutions to communicate. However, systematic evidence remains limited on how factional position influences the use of propaganda resources and the emphasis on issues as loyalty signals in everyday public communication, especially among senior subnational officials.

This study builds on these three literatures. We treat official news releases that document the daily activities of PPSs and PGs as key propaganda resources within China’s multi-level party-state. We extend the logic of issue politics to this setting by identifying a set of GS-owned issues linked to Xi Jinping’s core agenda. We then examine how provincial elites adjust their issue attention over time in response to changes in the GS’s agenda and whether factional proximity conditions this dynamic alignment once institutional role is taken into account. In doing so, we move beyond analyses of major propaganda campaigns or single-leader speeches to explore how subnational elites use routine propaganda to signal alignment and build reputations under contemporary Chinese authoritarianism.

Issue Signaling in Public-Activity Reports: Three Hypotheses

In nondemocratic regimes, elites are not held accountable through elections, but their political survival depends heavily on evaluations by superiors and on avoiding disciplinary action [18, 35, 36]. Formal theories of authoritarian personnel management highlight a trade-off between competence and loyalty: when rulers cannot credibly threaten punishment, they are more likely to favor loyal subordinates and closely monitor loyalty signals [37, 38]. Recent research on elite purges shows that even senior insiders remain vulnerable, as dictators selectively remove those who might

pose political risks [39]. In such contexts, local officials must continually demonstrate political reliability to the top leadership. Public-activity reports offer a convenient channel for such signaling. They are relatively low cost, institutionally sanctioned, and make issue attention visible to superiors.

Under Xi Jinping, the GS stands at the core of the CCP's political hierarchy. Although the premier retains important administrative responsibilities, Xi's consolidation of power and his status as the regime's "core" leader make his public agenda especially salient for subnational elites [12, 13]. Provincial officials, therefore, have strong incentives to track shifts in the GS's attention and to align their own agendas accordingly, while signals from the premier carry less weight for their long-term political prospects.

Hypothesis 1: In Xi-era China, increases in the share of attention that the general secretary devotes to an issue are associated with subsequent increases in provincial leaders' attention to that issue in public-activity reports. This responsiveness is stronger than the corresponding response to the premier's issue attention.

Local elites, however, do not respond equally to all policy areas. Authoritarian leaders often elevate a subset of issues into a "core agenda" that reflects their leadership identity and political priorities [26]. In China, research on Xi Jinping's tenure shows that several domains once managed by the State Council have been brought under tighter party control and are referred to as Xi's signature initiatives [11, 13]. For provincial officials with limited opportunities for public signaling, emphasizing these GS-owned issues is likely to yield greater reputational returns than focusing on routine administrative matters.

For local officials, investing in GS-owned issues provides an efficient way to demonstrate loyalty and initiative. These issues are directly tied to the leader's authority, are more closely monitored by the party center, and receive greater visibility in central propaganda. In contrast, generic administrative topics carry less symbolic value and attract less attention from above. We therefore expect provincial responsiveness to vary systematically across issues.

Hypothesis 2: Provincial leaders are more responsive to the general secretary's attention on GS-owned issues than on non-owned issues; their public-activity agendas adjust more strongly when the GS highlights topics tied to his core agenda.

How elites respond to central signals may depend on both their formal office and their position within the regime's informal hierarchy. Research on campaign-style politics under Jiang and Hu highlights how highly visible political drives created opportunities for differentiated loyalty displays. Cadres with weaker patronage ties often had stronger incentives to "overperform" publicly, while better-connected insiders could rely more on established relationships and backstage access [4, 40]. If this logic carries over, political proximity to Xi could still shape how strongly provincial leaders adjust their outward attention when they face the same central cues.

Several features of Xi-era politics, however, suggest that systematic factional differentiation in routine public signaling is more difficult to sustain, especially on issues closely associated with the general secretary's agenda. Recent work has characterized the post-2012 system as moving toward a dominant-faction setting, in which the political center is more clearly defined and alternative patronage networks are more constrained [6]. In such settings, leaders have incentives to demand repeated and observable demonstrations of alignment, and elites face heightened risks from visible deviation [37, 38, 41]. This logic is particularly strong for GS-owned issues, where the political meaning of "attentiveness" is clearer and comparisons across provinces are easier. For both core and peripheral elites, tracking shifts in the attention of the GS through routine publicity is therefore a relatively safe and institutionally sanctioned response. Moreover, the room for stable differentiation is limited. Doing noticeably less is risky, while doing much more often results in limited additional political return and can increase exposure to mistakes and scrutiny. As a result, core and noncore elites may converge on similar levels of outward responsiveness on leader-owned issues, even if informal ties continue to matter through other channels.

Formal office provides a clearer basis for expecting heterogeneous responsiveness. Provincial party secretaries are the Party's top political agents in the provinces and bear primary responsibility for political discipline and propaganda work. Governors, by contrast, lead provincial governments and are more tightly linked to day-to-day administration and policy implementation [42]. These role differences map onto distinct monitoring and career incentives within the Party's personnel management system, which provides the center with tools to evaluate, discipline, and promote local elites [35, 36]. Because public-activity reports are produced inside the Party's reporting system, party secretaries face stronger pressure to package their public agendas in ways that are legible as political alignment with the center, whereas governors face weaker and more constrained incentives to do so. We therefore expect responsiveness to GS signals on GS-owned issues to differ primarily by office (party secretary versus governor), while within each office, differences between core and peripheral elites are limited and do not show a stable, directional pattern.

Hypothesis 3: On GS-owned issues, both core and peripheral provincial elites respond positively to changes in the attention of the GS. Compared with governors, party secretaries respond more strongly. Within each office, core-peripheral differences are limited and do not exhibit a systematic pattern.

Research Design

Data

Studies of issue attention and issue ownership in democracies often draw on media coverage, legislative debates, party manifestos, and surveys to trace how political actors prioritize policy domains over time [2, 3]. In authoritarian systems, where competition for votes is absent, elites signal their priorities through the pattern of rou-

tine public appearances. These appearances allow leaders to communicate upward to superiors, laterally to peers, and outward to domestic and international audiences.

To capture these elite-level dynamics in China, we assembled an original dataset of textual records documenting the public activities of central and provincial leaders between 2016 and 2022. At the subnational level, our core source is the front pages of provincial party newspapers, which report the daily activities of PPSs and PGs. These articles summarize leaders' official schedules—including inspections, meetings, conferences, signing ceremonies, and other formal events. For the central level, we use reports on General Secretary Xi Jinping and Premier Li Keqiang published by Xinhua News Agency and the People's Daily, supplemented with entries from the official Xi Jinping Important Speeches database for the same period.

Within China's political hierarchy, the public activities of provincial leaders are regularly covered by provincial party newspapers, government portals, and state-run social media accounts. The texts we analyze are produced through routine publicity procedures. In many provinces, designated staff in the relevant party-state general offices and information units draft short news releases based on leaders' schedules and event materials. Provincial reporting guidelines in Guangdong, for example, specify that drafts for leaders' official activities are prepared by assigned staff and submitted for leaders' review and approval before release.¹ As top provincial officials, PPSs and PGs can influence which activities are reported, which coattendees are mentioned, and how each event's issue focus is described. These reports are part of the broader propaganda apparatus but differ from doctrinal commentaries or centrally authored essays: they closely follow leaders' calendars, document concrete public interactions, and are commonly cleared through leaders' offices as part of internal review routines before publication. Pan, [43] and Yan and Yang [25] show that officials can use this reporting format to project distinct public images, placing different emphases on competence, benevolence, and loyalty. For our purposes, these reports offer the most consistent and fine-grained textual record of how senior provincial elites allocate rhetorical attention across policy issues in their day-to-day work.

Compared with formal documents such as annual government work reports, our dataset provides a finer temporal resolution and greater detail. In our corpus, the high frequency of these news releases allows monthly aggregation and enables us to track shifts in provincial issue attention across time and policy domains rather than annually. The corpus contains 71,460 news releases on the activities of 109 PPSs and 105 PGs from 31 provincial-level units, together with 648 central-level releases on Xi Jinping and Li Keqiang over the same period. This dataset enables direct comparisons between central and provincial leaders within a common issue space. It also allows us to examine how provincial agendas adjust in response to central signals. Additional information on data collection, cleaning, and coverage is provided in Appendix A.

¹. See, for example, Guangdong Provincial People's Government (2001), “广东省人民政府办公厅关于印发《广东省人民政府公文处理办法》的通知” (includes provisions on drafting and approval routines), available at: https://www.gd.gov.cn/zwgk/gongbao/2001/5/content/post_3360313.html (accessed 27 February 2026).

Methods

Topic Modeling and Issue Measures

To identify the issues structuring central and provincial agendas, we analyze the full corpus of official reports on the public activities of General Secretary Xi Jinping and Premier Li Keqiang. We treat the two leaders' reports as separate corpora and estimate topic models for each. Instead of predefining "signature Xi-era issues," we use unsupervised methods. These methods inductively extract recurring themes and consolidate them into a shared issue space.

We apply nonnegative matrix factorization (NMF) to the Chinese-language reports on Xi and Li separately. NMF produces additive topic representations that are straightforward to interpret and is widely used for text decomposition [44, 45]. After estimating models over a range of topic numbers, we retain $K = 30$ for each corpus as a pragmatic compromise between interpretability and model diagnostics. Following standard practice, we evaluate topic coherence using UMass, UCI, and NPMI and treat these metrics as diagnostics rather than as criteria to be maximized [46]; we also verify that the substantive topic structure at $K = 30$ is recoverable at nearby resolutions using a cross- K alignment check. See Appendix B2.1–B2.2 for the full diagnostic and preprocessing details.

The two sets of topics are then combined into a single list of policy issues through structured qualitative consolidation. For each model, two coders read the top keywords and short samples of high-probability documents, propose provisional labels, and flag topics that are either too diffuse to be assigned a clear policy domain or largely composed of boilerplate political language. In a second step, we compare topics across the two models and merge those that describe the same substantive issue (for example, Xi- and Li-topics both centered on education or health). Topics that remain vague after discussion are dropped. This process yields 34 distinct topics that cover the main domains appearing in Xi's and Li's public activities. As Table B5 in Appendix B shows, more of these topics are associated with areas that have become central to Xi's leadership—ideology, development strategy, security, and high-level economic coordination—while a smaller set corresponds to more traditional administrative portfolios.

We then classify topics by issue ownership. For each topic, we examine its share of Xi's and Li's total coverage over the study period together with its keywords and representative documents. Topics that receive systematically greater attention from Xi and align with his core agenda—ideological discipline, party building and cadre management, anticorruption, poverty alleviation, major development strategies, political security, and related themes—are coded as GS-owned. Topics that receive more attention from the premier and focus on macroeconomic management, regulation, service provision, and routine social policy are coded as premier-owned. That more topics fall into the GS-owned category is consistent with a wider centralization of issue authority during the period we study. Through leading small groups and party commissions on finance, reform, security, and related domains, the general secretary has expanded direct political oversight into areas once handled mainly through the State Council [11–13].

To track issue salience over time, we construct topic-specific keyword sets and use them to rescore all the reports. For each of the 34 topics, we begin with the most weighted NMF terms and retain candidate words that are semantically specific and appear frequently in both the central and provincial corpora. Three coders familiar with Chinese policy discourse independently rate each candidate on two criteria: (1) its relevance to the focal topic and (2) how accurately it captures that topic's meaning in the Xi-era political language. Words with low or inconsistent ratings are removed after discussion. The final lists contain five core keywords per topic in the main specification and ten in robustness checks. The complete keyword lists, examples of the consolidation process, and intercoder reliability statistics are presented in Appendix B3.

Using these keyword sets, we rescore all the reports from Xi (GS), Li (Premier), PPSs, and PGs. For actor a , topic j , and month t , we calculate the share of coverage devoted to topic j among all 34 topics. These monthly shares form the core variables used in the time series and panel analyses that follow.

Measuring Factional Proximity

The third hypothesis concerns heterogeneous responsiveness to central signals across elite groups. Testing H3 requires a transparent and replicable measure of officials' observable proximity to Xi's political network, which we introduce first before turning to the econometric specification. Factional alignment in CCP elite politics is conceptually important but empirically difficult to measure because "factions" are rarely formalized organizations with observable membership rosters. Instead, they are typically understood as informal and evolving coalitional arrangements rooted in patron–client ties, career dependencies, and strategic alliance formation under constraints of balancing and competition [47–49]. As a result, the core measurement challenge is to operationalize a latent political relationship using observable traces in biographies and careers while limiting overly inclusive classifications that could arise from weak or widely shared biographical commonalities.

Existing empirical work has pursued two broad strategies. A first tradition relies on qualitative classification and contextual knowledge to identify factions or coalition blocs in particular eras, often emphasizing interpretive evidence about patronage, shared political trajectories, and intra-elite contestation [47, 49]. A second, increasingly common strategy involves the construction of replicable proxies from publicly available biographical information—such as shared hometown or schooling, overlapping work histories, or direct reporting relationships—and uses these proxies to estimate the consequences of elite connections for promotion and policy outcomes [18, 50, 51]. This "structured biography" approach is attractive for transparency and scalability, but it also underscores a key limitation: individual proxies often contain substantial noise because shared background characteristics may reflect cohorting, geography, or bureaucratic assignment rather than genuine patron–client attachment. Consistent with this concern, our main measure does not rely on any single proxy, and we treat background similarities as supplementary information used only in sensitivity checks.

The limits of single-proxy measures are well documented. Fisman et al., [52] show that ties inferred from hometown or college overlap may not reflect political allegiance and can even be negatively associated with advancement when elite selection involves balancing or intrafactional competition. Relatedly, Shih et al., [18], Jia et al., [51], and Keller [50] show that results can be sensitive to how patronage-like ties are operationalized, underscoring the need for careful proxy construction and robustness checks. These concerns are especially salient in Xi-era politics, where coalition boundaries are difficult to observe and where the same biographical marker (e.g., a shared province or school) may not map cleanly onto durable political dependence.

Given these constraints, our strategy is intentionally conservative. In the main specification, we construct a deterministic composite score from three bounded components: Xi-era appointment timing, senior service in a narrowly defined set of central “hub” secretariat/general-office posts, and career proximity via documented direct subordinate ties or (more weakly) local overlap in Xi’s base areas; each component is capped to prevent mechanical inflation (Appendix C2–C3). The core status is then assigned using a prespecified threshold on the composite score so that no single indicator is sufficient for classification (Appendix C4). In our primary specification, we classify leaders as core if the composite score is at least 2 (score ≥ 2) and as noncore otherwise (Appendix C4.1). This design choice serves two purposes: (1) it reduces the risk that diffuse, low-information commonalities generate inflated alignment rates, and (2) it provides a transparent, replicable mapping from observable biographical traces to an interpretable proximity measure. Because the measurement of any proxy for factional proximity will be imperfect, this approach also suggests that estimated heterogeneity should be interpreted as conservative: classical measurement error in the moderator tends to attenuate interaction effects toward zero [53].

We provide full measurement details, including the indicator set, coding rules, and alternative definitions, in Appendix C. In addition, we report prespecified sensitivity checks in two ways. First, we vary the core/noncore cutoff and consider stricter and broader classification rules (including versions that require at least one strong-evidence component and versions that incorporate weaker-tie indicators). Second, we reestimate the H3 interaction models using continuous versions of the proximity score and “single-proxy” measures (e.g., hometown-only, school-only, or specific career overlap indicators) that interact with GS signals. These checks help evaluate whether conclusions depend on any single operationalization.

Econometric Modeling

Our empirical analysis proceeds in three steps. First, we examine aggregate agenda dynamics among the four actors using a vector autoregression (VAR) model to test Hypothesis 1. Second, we estimate province–topic–month distributed lag (DL) models to analyze issue-specific responses and variation by issue ownership (Hypothesis 2). Third, we extend the DL framework by incorporating factional variables to assess whether proximity to Xi’s core faction amplifies responsiveness to GS-owned topics (Hypothesis 3). Across all the models, we summarize the results in terms of the short-term cumulative effects of GS signals over a 0–3 month horizon.

Aggregate agenda dynamics (H1). For the aggregate analysis, we collapse the data into monthly time series of overall coverage shares for each actor—denoted GS_t , PM_t , PPS_t , and PG_t . These series are winsorized and standardized. We estimate a four-variable VAR(1) model:

$$Z_t = A_0 + A_1 Z_{t-1} + u_t,$$

where $Z_t = (GS_t, PM_t, PPS_t, PG_t)'$ and A_1 is a vector of shocks, estimated by ordinary least squares [54]. Orthogonalized impulse response functions (IRFs) trace how innovations in GS and PM coverage affect the agendas of PPSs and PGs over time [55, 56]. IRFs are computed using a Cholesky decomposition ordered as GS–Premier–PPS–PG and are traced over a ten-month horizon. Because VARs describe dynamic correlations rather than causal effects, we interpret these patterns as descriptive evidence on the timing and relative strength of agenda linkages.

Panel distributed lag models: Baseline and issue ownership (H1–H2) To analyze within-topic responses, we use a province–topic–month panel. The dependent variable is the (demeaned) share of PPS coverage devoted to topic j in province i and month t , denoted $pps_dm_share_{ijt}$; the equivalent measure for governors, $pg_dm_share_{ijt}$, is used in parallel analyses. The baseline distributed lag (DL) model relates provincial topic shares to lagged GS and premier signals on the same topic:

$$\begin{aligned} pps_dm_share_{ijt} = & \sum_{k=0}^3 \beta_k gs_dm_share_{ijt-k} + \\ & \sum_{k=0}^3 \gamma_k pm_dm_share_{ijt-k} + \\ & \mu_{ij} + \lambda_t + \epsilon_{ijt} \end{aligned}$$

where $gs_dm_share_{ijt}$ and $pm_dm_share_{ijt}$ are defined analogously for GS and premier. μ_{ij} are province–topic fixed effects, and λ_t are month fixed effects. We set the lag length to three months and cluster two-way standard errors by province–topic and month [57]. This specification provides within-topic evidence on overall alignment (H1) and forms the baseline for H2 and H3. An additional model interacts GS lags with a post-2018 dummy (March 2018 onward) to compare cumulative GS effects before and after the constitutional revision; robustness checks appear in Appendix D1.

To test Hypothesis 2 on selective responsiveness, we extend the DL model by interacting GS signals with the topic-level ownership indicator $owner_gs(j)$:

$$\begin{aligned} ppsdm_share_{ijt} = & \sum_{k=0}^3 \beta_k gsdm_share_{ijt-k} + \\ & \sum_{k=0}^3 \theta_k \left(gsdm_share_{ijt-k} \times owner_{gs(j)} \right) + \\ & \sum_{k=0}^3 \gamma_k pmdm_share_{ijt-k} + \mu_{ij} + \lambda_t + \epsilon_{ijt} \end{aligned}$$

The cumulative effect of GS on non-GS-owned topics is $\sum_{k=0}^3 \beta_k$; on GS-owned topics, it is $\sum_{k=0}^3 (\beta_k + \theta_k)$. Their difference, $\sum_{k=0}^3 \theta_k$, captures the additional responsiveness to GS-owned issues. We compute these linear combinations and confidence intervals using the delta method. A parallel set of models for PGs, replacing $pps_dm_share_{ijt}$ with $pg_dm_share_{ijt}$, provides supporting evidence. Alternative ownership coding and robustness checks appear in Appendix D4.

Factional heterogeneity (H3) For Hypothesis 3, we restrict the analysis to GS-owned topics and examine whether responsiveness to GS signals varies with a leader's political proximity to Xi. We operationalize proximity using the composite factional proximity score introduced above and classify provincial leaders as core versus noncore. Taking PPSs as an example, for GS-owned topics, the distributed lag model becomes the following:

$$pps_dm_share_{ijt} = \sum_{k=0}^3 \beta_k gs_dm_share_{ijt-k} + \sum_{k=0}^3 \phi_k \left(gs_dm_share_{ijt-k} \times core_pps_faction_i \right) + \sum_{k=0}^3 \gamma_k pm_dm_share_{ijt-k} + \mu_{ij} + \lambda_t + \epsilon_{ijt}$$

Here, $\sum_{k=0}^3 \beta_k$ is the cumulative GS effect for noncore PPSs, $\sum_{k=0}^3 (\beta_k + \phi_k)$ is the cumulative effect for core PPSs, and $\sum_{k=0}^3 \phi_k$ is the core–noncore difference. We estimate an analogous specification for PGs. We also report topic-specific core–noncore differences for GS-owned topics to assess whether any factional heterogeneity is concentrated in particular policy domains. Finally, Appendix D3 reports robustness checks that vary the core/noncore cutoff, impose stricter and broader classification rules, use the continuous proximity score, and test single-proxy measures of factional ties.

Results

Descriptive Pattern

We begin by examining how issue attention is distributed across leaders and policy domains. As a static benchmark, Table 1 reports the Pearson correlations between the monthly topic shares of the four actor groups. The correlation between the GS and PPSs is substantially greater than the corresponding correlations between the GS and PGs or between the premier and PPSs. This suggests that PPSs' agendas more closely mirror the GS's priorities, although these contemporaneous correlations do not yet

Table 1 Results of Pearson Correlation Analysis

GS	GS	Premier	PPS	PG
	1	0.095385	0.480435	0.342684
Premier	0.095385	1	0.233968	0.470425
PPS	0.480435	0.233968	1	0.781131
PG	0.342684	0.470425	0.781131	1

speak to timing or causality. Table 2 reports descriptive statistics for the key variables used in the panel analysis.

The average share of coverage devoted to each of the 34 topics by the four leadership types is compared in Fig. 1. The results reveal a clear division of labor at the center. The GS focuses more heavily on ideologically charged and campaign-oriented issues—such as ideological work, party organization, anticorruption, poverty alleviation, and major development strategies—whereas the premier focuses on domains traditionally associated with the State Council, including industrial policy, enterprise reform, labor, and infrastructure. At the provincial level, PPSs’ agendas resemble the GS’s issue profile, whereas PGs emphasize economic and administrative matters aligned with the premier’s portfolio. In short, provincial issue attention reflects the central division of labor: party secretaries align with the “party-building

Table 2 Descriptive Statistics for Key Variables

Variable	Description	Min.	Max.	Mean	Variance
pps_share	PPS topic share (share of coverage devoted to topic j)	0	0.681	0.029	0.002
pg_share	PG topic share (governors)	0	0.750	0.029	0.002
gs_share	GS topic share (General Secretary)	0	0.690	0.029	0.003
pm_share	Premier topic share	0	0.449	0.029	0.003
gs_owned	GS-owned topic indicator (1 = GS-owned, 0 = other)	0	1.000	0.706	0.208
pps_score_total	Faction proximity score to Xi, PPS (higher = closer)	0	3.000	1.175	0.313
core_pps_faction	Core faction dummy, PPS (1 = core, 0 = non-core)	0	1.000	0.160	0.134
pg_score_total	Faction proximity score to Xi, PG (higher = closer)	0	3.000	1.074	0.094
core_pg_faction	Core faction dummy, PG (1 = core, 0 = non-core)	0	1.000	0.016	0.015
N	Number of observations	82,824			

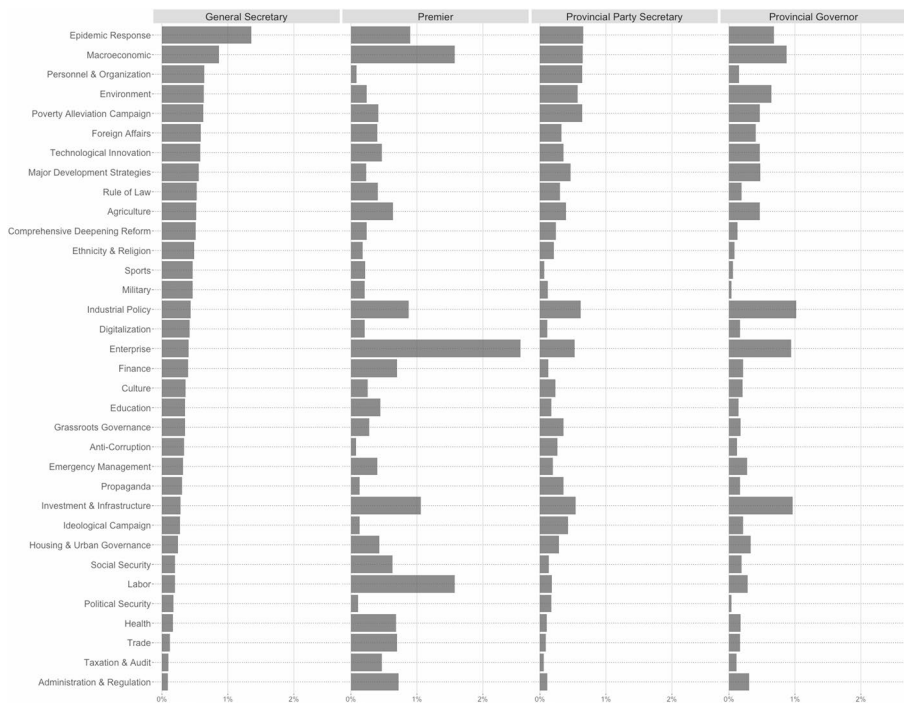


Fig. 1 Average Attention to 34 Topics by Central and Provincial Leaders *Note:* The vertical axis lists the 34 identified topics. The horizontal axis indicates the average proportion of keywords associated with each topic in the official activity reports of central and provincial leaders

and campaign” focus of the GS, whereas governors align more with the technocratic and economic orientation of the premier.

To illustrate the dynamics of alignment, we also examine monthly keyword trends for each topic (Appendix B4). With respect to several high-salience issues—such as ideological campaigns, anticorruption, and epidemic response—the peaks in attention of the GS coincide with sharp increases in provincial coverage. For many other issues, however, provincial attention varies independently. These descriptive patterns suggest that responsiveness among provincial elites is selective rather than uniform, motivating the time series and panel analyses that follow.

Overall Alignment with the General Secretary

We begin by assessing whether the GS signals shape the overall issue agendas of other leaders. Using monthly coverage shares across all 34 topics, we estimate a four-variable VAR model for the GS, premier, PPSs, and PGs. The orthogonal impulse response functions (IRFs) from this model are shown in Fig. 2. A one-time increase in the GS’s agenda share produces a clear and positive rise in both PPS and PG attention, peaking within one to two months and tapering off over the remainder of the ten-month horizon. In contrast, shocks to the premier’s agenda generate much

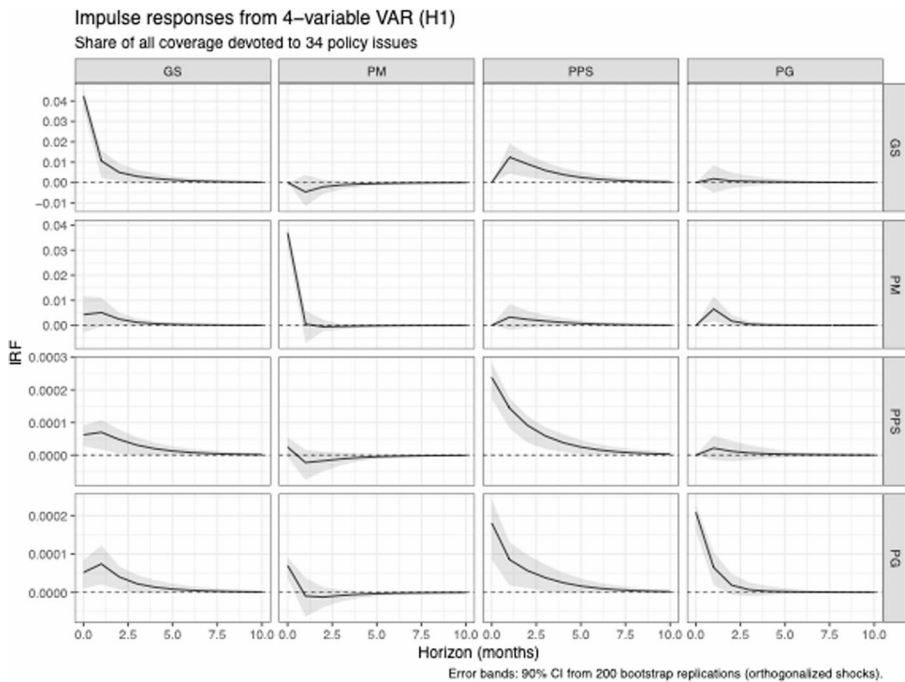


Fig. 2 Impulse Responses from Four-variable VAR (H1) *Note:* The panels show orthogonalized impulse responses from a VAR(1) of monthly coverage shares for GS, PM (Premier), PPS, and PG. Rows correspond to a one-standard-deviation shock to each actor (GS, PM, PPS, PG), and columns report the response of each actor's share of coverage devoted to the 34 policy issues. The horizontal axis is the forecast horizon in months (0–10); the vertical axis shows the change in issue share. Solid lines are point estimates and shaded areas are 90% bootstrap confidence bands based on 200 replications, using a Cholesky ordering GS–PM–PPS–PG

smaller and statistically weaker responses among provincial leaders, with confidence intervals largely overlapping zero.

A complementary panel analysis at the province–topic–month level reinforces this pattern and allows us to test whether it holds across different stages of Xi's rule. The March 2018 constitutional amendment removed presidential term limits and formally strengthened Xi's position as the regime's "core" leader. To check whether the observed alignment is driven only by the post-2018 period, we reestimate the distributed lag model with GS lags interacted with a post-2018 dummy and compare cumulative effects over a 0–3 month window. The estimated GS effect on PPS topic shares is approximately 0.12 before 2018 and 0.19 after 2018—a modest increase of 0.07 that is positive but only marginally significant (see Table D1, D2 and Figure D1 in Appendix D1).

These results provide strong evidence of sustained alignment between provincial leaders and the GS throughout the period. The effect appears somewhat stronger after 2018, but the shift seems gradual rather than abrupt.

Strategic Selection Across GS-owned Issues

We next examine whether the observed alignment is uniform across issues or stronger on those most closely associated with the GS. The cumulative 0–3-month effects of GS signals for topics classified as GS-owned and for other topics are shown in Fig. 3. This analysis uses the interaction models in Appendix Table D3.

For PPSs, the pattern is clear. With respect to non-GS-owned topics, GS signals have a small but statistically significant positive effect on provincial attention. With respect to GS-owned topics, the cumulative effect is several times greater, and the difference between the two is statistically significant. In other words, party secretaries respond to the GS on a broad range of issues, but they adjust their agendas much more when the issue falls within his core portfolio. Premier signals also increase PPS attention, but their cumulative impact is noticeably smaller than the effect of GS signals on GS-owned topics.

For PGs, we see the same ranking but at lower levels. On non-GS-owned issues, the effect of the GS on governors' attention is small and only weakly estimated. On GS-owned issues, the cumulative effect is clearly positive and substantially greater. The owned–nonowned difference is statistically distinguishable from zero. Even for governors whose day-to-day responsibilities are closer to the premier's administrative domain, attention is most responsive to GS signals on issues tied to Xi's leadership profile. Premier cues also matter for PG agendas, but they do not overturn the stronger pull of GS signals on GS-owned topics.

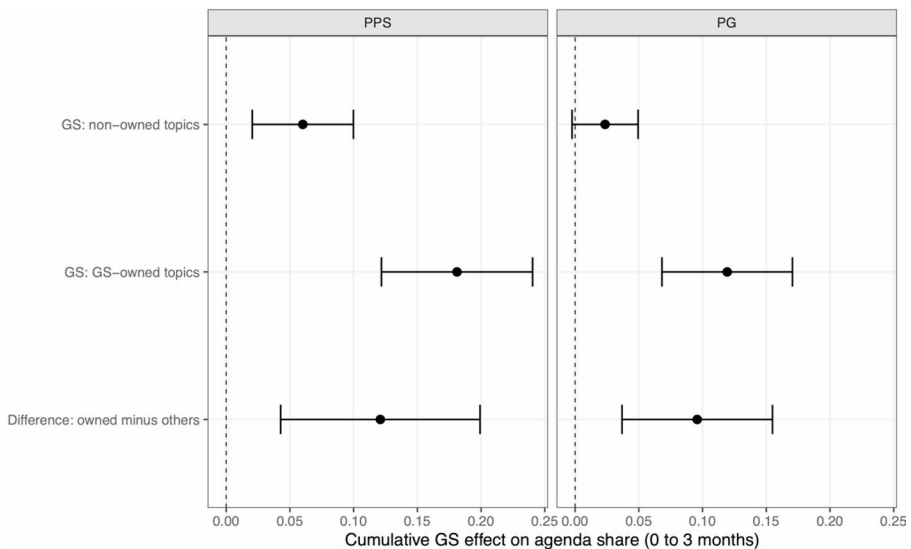


Fig. 3 Cumulative GS Effects on GS-owned versus Other Topics (H2) *Note:* Point estimates of the 0–3 month cumulative effect of GS signals on provincial agenda shares from distributed-lag models with topic-ownership interactions (see Table D3). The left panel shows PPS responses; the right panel shows PG responses. The horizontal axis measures the change in the share of coverage devoted to a topic, and the vertical axis lists GS effects on non-owned topics, on GS-owned topics, and their difference (owned minus others). Dots are cumulative coefficient sums and horizontal lines are 95% confidence intervals; the dashed vertical line marks zero

Overall, these results support Hypothesis 2. Provincial leaders do not respond mechanically to all central cues. Their responsiveness is selective and most pronounced on issues that define the GS's agenda, while their reactions to other, more premier-related issues are clearly weaker.

Factional Proximity and Responsiveness to Leader-owned Issues

Building on the ownership results in H2, we next examine whether factional proximity to Xi shapes how provincial leaders respond to signals on GS-owned issues. Existing work on Xi-era elite politics emphasizes the concentration of authority in the general secretary and the weakening of alternative patronage poles [6, 7, 17]. In such a setting, both core and noncore elites plausibly face strong incentives to echo the GS's agenda in public-facing provincial activities. H3 therefore does not predict large divergences; instead, it treats factional heterogeneity as a conditional possibility—potentially visible at the margin but likely limited on issues closely associated with the top leader's portfolio.

The cumulative 0–3-month effects of GS signals on GS-owned issues are shown in Fig. 4, which separates core and noncore elites and distinguishes between PPSs and

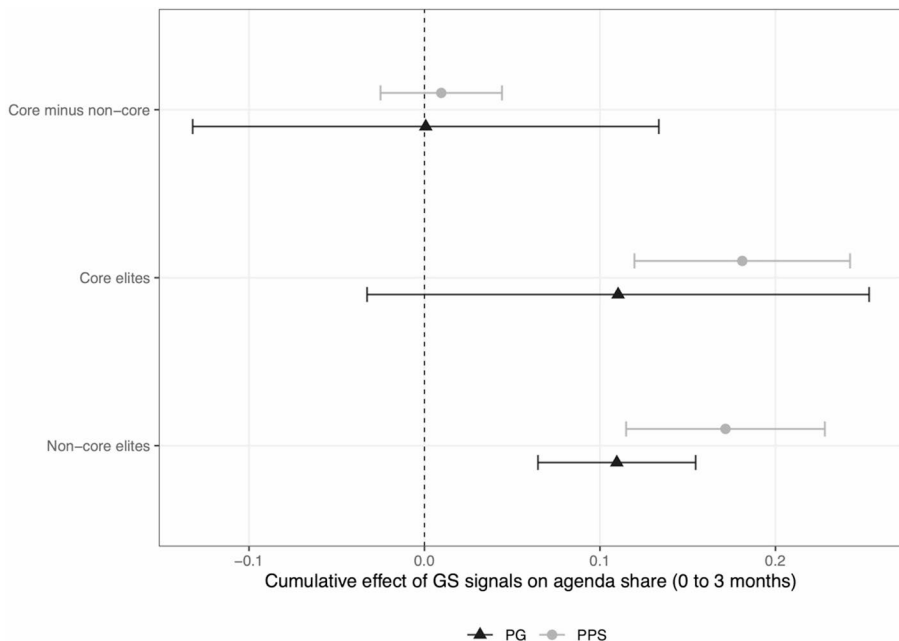


Fig. 4 Factional Proximity and Responsiveness to GS Signals (H3) *Note:* Cumulative 0–3 month effects of GS signals on agenda share from distributed-lag models with core–faction interactions, for GS-owned topics. The horizontal axis shows the change in the share of provincial coverage devoted to a topic; the dashed vertical line marks zero. The three rows report, from bottom to top, the effects for non-core elites, core elites, and the difference (core minus non-core). Grey circles refer to PPSs and black triangles to PGs. Dots are cumulative effects and horizontal lines are 95% confidence intervals

PGs. Table D4 in Appendix D reports the corresponding regression estimates. Three patterns emerge.

First, among PPSs, the cumulative GS effect is large and precisely estimated for both groups. Stronger GS signals on GS-owned topics are associated with sizeable increases in issue attention for noncore party secretaries, and the estimates for core party secretaries are very similar. The implied core–noncore difference is small and not statistically distinguishable from zero. Substantively, this is consistent with the intuition behind H3: once a dominant faction consolidates authority, both insiders and outsiders have strong incentives to align outward signaling with the GS on leader-owned issues, leaving limited room for factionally differentiated displays. Across both the core and noncore groups, PPS estimates are also consistently larger than the corresponding PG estimates (Fig. 4), matching the office-based component of H3.

Second, relative to PPSs, governors respond to GS signals in the same direction but with smaller magnitudes; precision is high for noncore governors but substantially lower for core governors, reflecting their small numbers. For both core and noncore PGs, the cumulative effect of GS on GS-owned topics is positive, but the estimated core–noncore differences remain small and imprecise. Two constraints make these estimates less informative: only a small number of governors meet our core-faction criteria, and governors are institutionally further from the political center than party secretaries are. We therefore treat the PG evidence as secondary and place greater weight on PPSs, the CCP's top provincial representatives.

Third, premier signals are included as controls in all specifications. Their cumulative effects on GS-owned topics are generally positive, but our focus is on GS responsiveness; we do not interpret the premier coefficients as independent agenda leadership on GS-owned issues. Given how GS-owned topics are defined, responsiveness to premier cues on these issues likely reflects coordinated messaging rather than competing agenda setting.

To probe whether heterogeneity is concentrated in specific policy areas, we reestimate the distributed-lag model separately for each GS-owned topic and compute topic-specific core–noncore contrasts. These contrasts for PPSs and PGs are presented in Fig. 5, and Tables D8 and D9 report the corresponding estimates (Appendix D). The topic-level results largely reinforce the pooled findings: most contrasts cluster close to zero. A small subset of topics shows statistically discernible gaps, including a few with larger deviations, but the signs are mixed, and the differences do not organize into a coherent pattern across offices or domains; the set of reliable contrasts also shrinks further once we adjust for multiple testing.

Across alternative operationalizations of factional proximity, including stricter and broader core definitions, a continuous proximity score, and single-proxy indicators, the substantive pattern remains the same: core–noncore differences are generally small and estimated imprecisely, whereas office-based differences (PPS versus PG) are more salient. One notable exception is that a small number of single-proxy checks yield significant differences in the opposite direction—for example, governors coded as having a direct tie and party secretaries with hub-post experience in 2008–2012 display weaker responsiveness—reinforcing the view that observable proximity does not translate into systematically stronger outward signaling. Appendix D3 reports these robustness checks in detail.

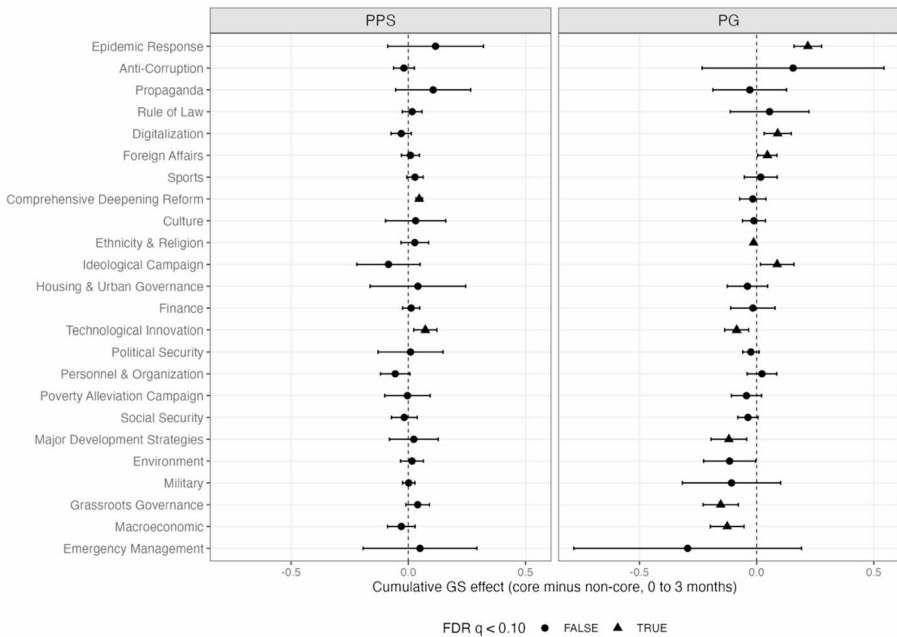


Fig. 5 Topic-level Core–non-core Differences in Responsiveness to GS Signals (H3) *Note:* Cumulative 0–3 month differences in GS effects between core and non-core elites on GS-owned topics, from topic-by-topic distributed-lag models. The left panel reports results for PPSs and the right panel for PGs. The horizontal axis shows the estimated GS effect for core elites minus the effect for non-core elites; the dashed vertical line marks zero. Each dot is a topic-specific estimate and horizontal lines are 95% confidence intervals. Most topics cluster near zero, with only a few showing noticeably larger gaps

Taken together, the evidence indicates positive responsiveness for both core and noncore elites, a clear PPS–PG gap, and only limited, unsystematic factional heterogeneity within offices, which is consistent with the view that outward signaling in Xi’s era is more strongly associated with institutional role and centralized incentives than with observable factional proximity [17].

Discussion and Conclusion

This study examines how provincial leaders in China adjust the issue composition of routine public-activity reports in response to central signals. Using 71,460 official public-activity reports from 2016 to 2022, we track monthly issue attention for the general secretary, the premier, provincial party secretaries, and governors. Three findings summarize the evidence. First, provincial agendas are more strongly associated with the GS’s agenda than with the premier’s agenda. Second, responsiveness is stronger for leader-owned issues tied to the GS’s core portfolio, whereas attention to more routine administrative issues is less elastic. Third, compared with factional alignment, observed heterogeneity appears to be more strongly associated with institutional roles. PPSs respond more strongly than PGs do, whereas within offices, core–noncore differences are generally small, topic dependent, and imprecisely estimated.

These results speak to issue attention and agenda control in authoritarian politics. In electoral settings, issue ownership highlights how parties cultivate reputations and emphasize certain issues to win votes [2, 3]. In Xi-era China, the relevant hierarchy is instead defined from the top: the leader's agenda provides a reference point, and subnational elites adapt their public-facing portfolios accordingly. We term this pattern authoritarian issue politics—upward-facing, issue-specific alignment embedded in routine propaganda rather than electoral competition.

The analysis also clarifies the internal function of propaganda in authoritarian governance. More broadly, these center–local dynamics may matter beyond elite coordination alone, echoing recent work showing that local leader relations can shape orientations toward the political center in China [58]. While much work emphasizes propaganda as a mass-facing instrument [5, 22, 59], public-activity reports also operate as a standardized venue in which officials demonstrate attentiveness to the center. The key choice is often which issues to foreground when reporting routine inspections, meetings, and policy work; over time, these repeated issue choices cumulate into durable, comparable patterns that are legible to superiors.

Do these findings imply that factions are “meaningless” in Xi's China? Our evidence supports a narrower interpretation. Using a conservative, replicable proximity measure and extensive sensitivity checks, we find limited and unsystematic evidence that observable proximity systematically amplifies responsiveness to leader-owned issues. This is not evidence that informal ties do not matter. Rather, it suggests that on highly salient leader-owned issues, routine publicity may be shaped by strong convergence pressures in personalist settings [41], leaving little room for stable within-office faction gradients. If factional advantages persist, they may operate through other channels, such as access or claim-making in alternative venues, rather than through more intensive public signaling [19].

Several limitations qualify the scope of inference. Our measures rely on public reports shaped by editorial conventions and cannot capture private communication. Our design is observational; thus, even with dynamic specifications and extensive fixed effects, some shared shocks or coordination may remain. Finally, the analysis focuses on provincial leaders in Xi-era China; issue signaling may differ at lower administrative levels or under less personalized leadership. Future work can link signaling patterns to career outcomes, examine substitution between public and less visible channels, and extend comparable public-activity data to other contexts.

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Authors' contributions Yang Yan: Conceptualization; Methodology; Formal analysis, writing.

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Data Availability Replication materials are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

Declarations

Ethics Approval and Consent to Participate Not applicable. This study analyzes publicly available news reports and does not involve human participants or identifiable private information.

Consent for Publication Not applicable.

Conflict of interest The authors declare that they have no competing interests.

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